CRITTER CAPTURE

The Master Plan

THE SHORT VERSION

Critter Capture is a monster-catching role-playing game in the Game Boy tradition, rebuilt to a modern standard and played in a browser on a tablet or in a headset. It is not a small tribute. It is planned as a full-sized game with a long tail: a region of roughly thirty-eight areas, one hundred or more creatures, eight badge challenges and a league, spread across three chapters that each ship as a complete game.

The aim is not to be bigger than the games that inspired it. It is to be distinctive, dense and premium - a game with one idea of its own that nobody else in the genre has, and enough content to keep a player busy for years.

THE TARGETS AT FULL SIZE

Creatures - one hundred or more, across three chapters
Chapters - three, each a complete game in its own right
Badge challenges - eight, plus a final league gauntlet
Areas - about thirty-eight, from coast to mountain to tower
Field powers - five, each opening routes you could see but not reach
Types - twelve, on a chart of our own
Region - one, Rivenmoor, extended chapter by chapter
Post-game - a repeatable battle facility and leaderboards

THE REGION AT FULL SIZE

The region is Rivenmoor. The full journey runs in one long line that keeps opening: a coastal home village, three towns in a wooded valley, a lake crossing, a mining town, a mountain pass, a coastal city, and finally the league tower.

At full size the region holds about thirty-eight areas:

- six towns
- three crossing routes
- two forests
- two cave systems
- a coast and a sea route
- a mountain
- a marsh
- a ruins
- the league approach and the league tower
- plus interiors: houses, shops, healing centres and challenge halls

Each leg is gated by a badge or a field power, so progress is also permission. You can see where you are not yet allowed to go, which is what makes exploring feel like achievement rather than wandering.

Time of day shifts the colour of the world and changes what appears in the grass. Some creatures come out only at night; others only in rain. Weather changes the light itself, not just an overlay on top of it.

THE FIVE FIELD POWERS

Field powers are the reason the map keeps opening. Each is earned from a challenge, and each opens routes you could see but not reach before.

1. Swim - cross open water
2. Shove - push boulders out of the way
3. Glow - light the dark caves
4. Glide - cross gaps and drop from ledges
5. Climb - scale rock walls

Chapter One awards the first two. The rest arrive as the region grows.

THE CREATURES AT FULL SIZE

The roster is the spine of the collection game. It is planned at one hundred or more species, built up over three chapters:

Chapter One - thirty-six species
Chapter Two adds - thirty more
Chapter Three adds - thirty-four more
Full total - one hundred species

All of it is built as data, not code. A creature is a row of numbers and a sprite reference: name, types, base statistics, growth curve, learnset, evolution, catch rate, rarity and habitat. The roster therefore grows by adding entries rather than features, and balance changes are file edits rather than rewrites.

THE TWELVE TYPES

The type chart is our own, not borrowed: Ember, Tide, Verdant, Stone, Gale, Spark, Frost, Shade, Radiance, Iron, Wild and Mind. Twelve is enough for a rich set of strengths, weaknesses and immunities, and few enough that a player can actually learn it. Every type has at least two strengths and is weak to at least two others.

WHAT EVERY CREATURE CARRIES

- six statistics: health, attack, defence, special attack, special defence, speed
- hidden individual values, so two of a species are never identical
- a nature from a table of twenty-five, favouring one stat and hindering another
- training values earned in battle, on a fixed budget
- at least one passive ability that fires on its own
- a rarity tier, and a place in a two- or three-stage evolution line
- a heritage record - see Lineage

THE SYSTEMS - THE CORE DEPTH

These are the systems the game is not deep without. All are planned for the full release, not a later one:

- types and a full effectiveness chart
- the six statistics, with individual values, natures and training values
- passive abilities, at least one per species
- moves with power, accuracy, limited uses, priority, and a physical or special split
- five status conditions: Scorch, Blight, Static, Slumber and Chill
- statistic stages, six steps down to six steps up
- critical hits, damage variance and type multipliers
- held items with battle effects
- switching, a party of six, and storage beyond that
- double battles - needed for co-op, and used in single play too
- catching with tiered balls and a visible throw sequence
- experience, growth, learning moves on level, and evolution
- trainers, with their own teams and prize money
- an opponent that switches, heals, and plays to its type advantages
- day and night, weather, and terrain that matters
- breeding, with clear inheritance rules
- rare colourways that are heritable rather than random
- difficulty modes
- the dex, which is the collection game

THE STRETCH LIST

Systems that make the game bigger rather than deeper, and come after the core:

- a post-game battle facility, with streaks and prizes
- move tutors, machines, and egg moves
- fishing and foraging
- in-game trades
- legendary creatures, found once
- rewards for completing the dex
- trainer rematches
- contests and a photo mode
- version exclusives, tied to trading

THE SIGNATURE MECHANIC - LINEAGE

Every memorable game in this genre is remembered for the one thing it does differently. Ours is Lineage, and it is the reason to play this one.

Most games give you a rare colour variant that is random and cannot be influenced. Ours is heritable, and that single change turns a lottery into a project.

Every creature carries a permanent, visible record of where it came from and what it inherited. It has three parts:

Heritage traits
Inherited, and they affect battle. Breeding combines the parents' traits under clear rules, so chaining generations produces combinations that do not exist in the wild at all.

Marks
Visible patterns and colours that show ancestry. Because Marks are heritable, a player can breed toward the look they want instead of hoping for it.

Origin
The wild area it came from, or the player whose line it descends from, shown as a small family tree on the creature's card.

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE FOR US THAN FOR ANYONE ELSE

Breeding generates near-infinite variety from data. It costs no new art, no new sprites and no new code - only combinations. It is the one axis where a small team can genuinely out-produce a large studio, and it is the engine that keeps the collection game alive for years.

It also changes what trading means. A trade is not swapping a stat block. It is swapping a history, and that is what makes a collection emotional rather than arithmetic.

THE DRIFT

Released creatures do not simply vanish. They drift into other players' worlds with their lineage attached, so a player can meet someone else's bloodline in their own grass. Breeding, releasing, trading and exploring become one loop, and exploration gains a reason beyond your own collection.

MULTIPLAYER, TRADING AND VERSIONS

Two players can share a battle, cooperatively. That is rare in this genre and it is a deliberate differentiator - and the battle engine is built around a list of participants from the first day, so co-op is not a rewrite.

Trading is live and in-room. Both players hold their confirm button at the same moment for a trade to complete, so a trade can never happen by accident.

The game ships as two versions, Dawn and Dusk. Most creatures appear in both, and each version has a handful of exclusives. That gives trading a real purpose, and gives the multiplayer room a reason to exist beyond battling.

Multiplayer is always an enhancement and never a dependency. If the connection is down, the game still starts, plays and saves alone.

HOW IT SHIPS - THREE CHAPTERS

Chapter One is a complete game of roughly ten to twelve hours: four badge challenges, about twenty areas, thirty-six creatures and two field powers, with its own beginning, middle and ending, and threads deliberately left open.

Chapter One - four challenges, about twenty areas, thirty-six creatures
Chapter Two adds - three challenges, ten areas, thirty creatures
Chapter Three adds - one challenge and the league, eight areas, thirty-four creatures
Full total - eight challenges plus the league, about thirty-eight areas, one hundred creatures, five field powers

Each chapter resolves its own story and ships finished. Stopping after any one of them is never a loss, which is what makes a plan this size survivable.

PRESENTATION - THE LOOK

The target is HD-2D: hand-drawn pixel creatures standing in a three-dimensional world, with a shallow depth of field that makes the scene look like a small diorama, plus real lighting, glow and drifting particles. It is exactly what a Game Boy game, remade means today, and it is what makes a browser game look like a premium product rather than a tribute.

It is also a rendering layer rather than a different game. The world stays a grid of tiles underneath, so the ambitious part cannot break the part that works. It is planned as a deliberate late stage, with a graphics setting that falls back to flat, crisp pixel art if a device struggles.

HOW IT GETS BUILT

The work is staged so that every stage ends with something playable:

0. Skeleton - the overworld, one map, one encounter, one battle
1. Battle depth - types, moves, abilities, status, identity, catching, growth
2. World systems - many maps, non-player characters, dialogue, trainers, shops
3. Content - the full roster, moves, encounter tables, the dex
4. Progression - the challenges, field powers, the rival, the plot, the ending
5. Presentation - HD-2D, audio, animation, and performance on real devices
6. Multiplayer - co-op battles over a live room, then trading
7. Endgame - the battle facility, leaderboards, accessibility, polish

Stages 0 and 1 are done and playable. Stage 2 is in progress.

ART AND COST

Art is planned to cost approximately nothing, which is what makes a roster of a hundred creatures realistic rather than a wish:

- public-domain sprite packs for the first creatures, licence-clean and free
- creatures assembled from parts on a shared palette, so variety comes from data rather than drawing
- a small number of painted poster pieces for bosses and box art

The look is held together by one shared palette and one tile grid, so every source sits in the same world.

WHAT IT IS NOT

Honesty matters more than optimism here. This is not, and will not be, a match for the biggest games in the genre on content volume - those are built by hundreds of people over decades. What it can be, and what this plan aims at, is a tight, beautiful, distinctive game with a mechanic nobody else has.

WHERE IT IS TODAY

The foundation is built and playable: the overworld, wild encounters, the full turn-based battle engine, catching, experience, evolution, party management, creature identity and the abilities surface. Work is now on the world itself - non-player characters, dialogue, trainers, and the second town.

Everything in this document that is not yet built is planned, not promised.